



Costly miss: In her semifinal against Muchova, Coco Gauff blew a match point serving 9-8 in the final set tie-break. REUTERS

my ex-friend. I'm kidding ... sort of."

Noskova's speech was just as touching and endearing. "It feels incredible," she said. "All these matches have been so tough physically and mentally. I'm so glad I could play my first Grand Slam final with you. I think we made history today." They sure did, becoming the first two players from the same country to contest a Grand Slam singles final since Serena Williams beat her sister Venus in the 2017 Australian Open final. She was also the youngest Wimbledon champion since compatriot Petra Kvitová in 2011.

"I want to thank my dad for coming here," Noskova continued. "I want to thank my mom. I definitely would not be standing here without

her." Her mother passed away two years ago. As she shed a few tears, she said, "I don't cry normally."

Gauff's gaffe

Both players had narrowly escaped defeat before the final. Noskova had stared down a match point in her third-round comeback 2-6, 6-3, 7-6(9) win over No. 17-seeded Sorana Cîrstea, who led 7-5 in the match tie-break.

Muchova also staved off a match point against No. 7 seed Coco Gauff in their riveting, fluctuating, and always unpredictable 6-2, 1-6, 7-6(10) duel. Gauff had match point serving at 9-8 in the tie-break but inexplicably blew it. With a weak, shoulder-high ball she should have pounded, she choked and tapped a forehand drop shot into the net. "That will haunt her in her sleep," said *ESPN* analyst Caroline Wozniacki.

"That match tie-break had everything," said *ESPN* analyst Mary

Joe Fernandez. "Muchova went all out to hit forehands and avoid backhands. She was the one to take it to Coco. To win this tournament, you have to be brave." Muchova, who had lost her first six matches to Gauff and then won matches on clay and grass, told *Tennis Channel*, "If I'm going to lose, I'm going to lose on my own terms. I like to entertain and create. That's the way I've played since I was a kid."

In the other semifinal, Noskova stopped No. 12 seed Marta Kostyuk of Ukraine, 6-4, 6-4. A former gymnast, Kostyuk switched to tennis because she had to be careful with her weight. "There was so much stress," she recalled. An elite athlete, Kostyuk quickly excelled in tennis, winning the Australian Open junior title at age 14. "It was almost like a curse," she said.

"We've had great expectations since she was a great junior," said Wozniacki. But like many elite juniors, she initially struggled on the pro tour. Highly emotional and anguished by the Russian invasion and bombs that landed near her parents' home, Kostyuk said, "I worked hard not to define myself by winning or losing." After she upset Mirra Andreeva in the Madrid Open final, she did a backflip that went viral. At Wimbledon, Kostyuk used her power and foot speed to eliminate 23rd-seeded Emma Navarro and 2024 Roland Garros and Wimbledon finalist Jasmine Paolini.

Noskova's low-key upbringing in Bystřička, a village of less than 1,000 people in the Vsetín region of the Czech Republic, may account for her serene disposition on the hotly competitive WTA Tour. Though her tennis-playing parents introduced her to the game at age seven, she also enjoyed other sports and activities. "When I started, tennis was more of a hobby for me," she recalled. "I didn't expect to be here in a few years." Her talent blossomed under the astute coaching of Tomáš Krupa, and at 16, she won the 2021 French Open girls' title.

Eight years older than Noskova at 29, Muchova has for years drawn raves for her exceptional athleticism